

AI wastes energy on stupid videos – or is it?

Posted by u/lucidmodules • 0 points • 33 comments

I saw a comment on Instagram recently with thousands of likes saying: __40 gallons of water were spent to make this__.

While the environmental impact of AI is real and needs to be addressed, this narrative feels incredibly hypocritical when we look at the hidden footprint of the world we've already built. Here's why:

****1. The "Trash Streaming" Paradox****

We attack a GPU for running 30 seconds to create a video, but we ignore the massive, 24/7 infrastructure supporting degenerate influencers.

Millions of people watch 4K live streams of people engaging in toxic behavior, public harassment, or just sleeping for hours on end.

This requires global CDNs, massive bandwidth, and thousands of servers running 24/7.

If we judge AI by utility, why is a 10-hour stream of someone screaming in public a valid use of the power grid, while AI experimentation is labeled as waste?

****2. Baudrillard and the cost of the Simulacrum****

In __Simulacra and Simulation__, Jean Baudrillard noted how we often destroy reality just to create its image.

To film a simulation of war in *Apocalypse Now*, the production actually destroyed real jungles in the Philippines with napalm and heavy machinery.

AI allows us to explore the most destructive human imaginations (war, disasters, sci-fi) entirely within the digital realm. It costs electrons, but it doesn't burn a single real tree or require a physical film set. Moving from physical spectacle to digital simulation is actually a conservation strategy.

****3. The Logistics of Traditional Entertainment****

A standard Hollywood production or a major TV show is a logistical nightmare for the environment.

Hundreds of crew members flying across the globe, fleets of trucks, massive diesel generators, and incredible amounts of catering waste and plastic.

Massive studios and stadiums require constant heating, cooling, and lighting regardless of their occupancy.

In the meantime AI moves bits, not atoms. It allows for the creation of special effects without the carbon footprint of a 200-person film crew traveling to a remote location.

****4. The Hidden Costs of Human Labor****

A team of editors and VFX artists working for a month consumes a vast amount of resources: food, water, transportation, and office energy.

AI condenses that collective effort into a much more energy-efficient silicon process.

The energy per creative output might actually lean in favor of AI when you factor in the lifecycle of the humans involved in traditional production.

We are judging a new technology by its visible costs while ignoring the invisible, systemic waste of the status quo.

Is a “stupid AI video” really the problem, or is it just an easy scapegoat for a society that refuses to look at its own larger, physical waste?

Comments

u/NarwhalBig304 • 3 points • 2025-12-24 06:27 UTC

This is actually a pretty solid take. The whole "AI bad for environment" thing always felt weird to me when crypto mining was literally melting glaciers and nobody cared until it was trendy to hate on it

Like you said, traditional film production is absolutely insane from an environmental standpoint - entire crews flying around the world just to film someone walking through a door. At least with AI the "damage" is contained to some data centers instead of actual forests getting napalmed for Apocalypse Now lol

u/jacobpederson • 1 points • 2025-12-23 23:08 UTC

A hamburger is 600+ gallons of water https://watercalculator.org/footprint/what-is-the-water-footprint-of/ The problem has nothing to do with AI or water or anything like that. It's overpopulation. End of line.

u/itsReferent • 2 points • 2025-12-24 03:13 UTC

Did you know that the entire living population of earth can fit in lake Superior with 10 square meters a person?

<https://www.reddit.com/r/theydidthemath/s/UKfBI6xxxR>

There is plenty of space for all of us. Countries like south Korea are rapidly declining in population.

https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Demographics_of_South_Korea

We have to be more efficient with our resources. We have to stop burning fossil fuels.

u/jacobpederson • 1 points • 2025-12-24 11:16 UTC

It's not the weight or space of a human :D -- it's their footprint (see below). But yes, I agree that population growth is declining globally AND that its technically possible to live sustainably. I don't think a human will ever do it . . . but it's possible for sure.

<https://preview.redd.it/eyfmome1y49g1.png?width=2560&format=png&auto=webp&s=9bb272bf35c8142d1c17a41decdd446a19d4d626>

u/Cyberdeth • 2 points • 2025-12-23 22:52 UTC

A lot of the arguments regarding data center energy and water use will be moot once optical chips become viable.

u/AdUsual6372 • 1 points • 2025-12-24 09:37 UTC

once musk becomes a god like being he will give as all unlimited energy so this dicussion is moot

u/FunDiscount2496 • 1 points • 2025-12-23 22:48 UTC

Think about the savings of killing all editors and VFX artists in the planet! 🤪

u/Romanizer • 1 points • 2025-12-23 21:37 UTC

Not sure if you have a specific video in mind but whenever judging AI for the use of resources you have to compare to the alternative.

If you made the same video completely without AI (wherever you draw the line here), you would have probably spent a lot more money and used a lot more resources on that.

u/jontaffarsghost • 0 points • 2025-12-23 21:05 UTC

Some of these are stupid and some of these are very stupid.

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-12-23 20:52 UTC

[removed]

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2025-12-23 19:44 UTC

[removed]

u/peternn2412 • -2 points • 2025-12-23 19:21 UTC

Do you believe every random nonsense you read?

If so, read this:

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Every time someone reads this sentence you're reading right now, 40 fresh, brand new gallons of water are created out of nothing!

If you hit CTRL+F5 to reload the page, there are 40 new gallons!

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Please use responsibly, and the most important - keep it secret!

If many people start reading the above sentence, it may cause floodings worldwide!

u/guitarot • 2 points • 2025-12-23 19:10 UTC

I've been goofing around with very small LLM models on my gaming laptops, but I use way more power with my GPUs playing games.

u/toccobrador • 3 points • 2025-12-23 18:31 UTC

Whatever, we're already in overshoot territory. If AI can accelerate fusion then we can maybe save our civilizational bacon but otherwise online hand-wringing over AI power consumption is the same game as plastic recycling and buying organic - performative gestures from privilege that change nothing.

u/itsReferent • -1 points • 2025-12-23 19:15 UTC

Yessir. It does appear to be accelerating nuclear fusion adoption in the US. When energy becomes cheap and renewable, ai does not matter at all from an energy standpoint.

u/toccobrador • -1 points • 2025-12-23 19:51 UTC

Def! If fusion's a thing then desalination becomes a thing, then vertical farming, & who knows what resource constraints couldn't be dealt with. The best timeline. Hard to imagine, really.

u/Ciappatos • 0 points • 2025-12-23 17:51 UTC

"this narrative feels incredibly hypocritical when we look at the hidden footprint of the world we've already built"

No, it doesn't. Because there's a concerted effort to reduce that footprint and making snuff films of disney characters is not a priority use of that budget.

u/mikeigartua • 1 points • 2025-12-23 17:45 UTC

The points you bring up about the hidden environmental costs of traditional media versus the visible impact of new tech like AI are really insightful. It's easy to point fingers at the new thing without stepping back to consider the full picture of what we've already built and continue to consume. Your detailed breakdown, from the "trash streaming" paradox to the logistics of Hollywood and even the human labor footprint, shows you have a sharp eye for nuance in these discussions. It makes a lot of sense to question why some forms of energy consumption are normalized while others are scrutinized so heavily, especially when the newer methods might offer efficiencies we're not fully acknowledging yet. Thinking about how AI can condense creative effort and avoid the physical destruction noted by Baudrillard really shifts the perspective. Given how thoughtfully you're looking at the future of digital content and its implications, I was thinking you might find something interesting in a remote role I heard about. It involves helping with [AI Videos]

(https://work.mercor.com/jobs/list_AAABmigPy8eAQ3aVkQhMcaEj?referralCode=561d8e89-98bf-43d2-abb9-d4ab0c46b1ba&utm_source=share&utm_medium=referral&utm_campaign=job_referral)

training, analyzing short clips, and giving feedback to improve models. It's all creative work, no calls or meetings, 100% non-phone, pays \$40 an hour, fully remote with a flexible schedule. Someone with your attention to detail and perspective on this space would probably be really good at it. God bless.

u/SuperMolasses1554 • 4 points • 2025-12-23 17:37 UTC

Honestly people just latch onto the new thing. Nobody asks how much energy TikTok, Netflix, or Twitch burn every second, but one AI video pops up and suddenly everyone's an environmental expert.

u/shyymamas • 2 points • 2025-12-23 17:26 UTC

The whole "AI is killing the planet" argument falls apart when you look at what we already waste resources on. People stream themselves sleeping for 12 hours and nobody bats an eye about those server farms running 24/7.

u/Saarbarbarbar • 0 points • 2025-12-23 17:22 UTC

"degenerate"? Why do you speak like a nazi?

u/lucidmodules • 1 points • 2025-12-23 23:56 UTC

What I had in mind are certain types of influencers. For example those going to Japan and disrespecting local customs for views.

u/Seidans • 0 points • 2025-12-23 17:20 UTC

Anything relevant to this argument (waste of compute/energy etc etc) also exist on internet as a whole, with most of the traffic being use for entertainment and pornography - the same thing happen for AI, it's mainly use for entertainment and parasocial interaction

And what we seen with internet is that trying to limit the use of internet, social media, porn, entertainment is always seen negatively

Would people like a permit of GenAI or AI use the same way some politician want your registered ID to access internet content? Imho any attempt to limit GenAI can only be negative, it's a far better option (socially, ethic) to just increase the amont of compute and infrastructure

Energy and environment-wise it's politician you should complaint that your energy grid isn't either nuclear or renewable